awaiting me. As soon as we stepped into the lobby the lights were dimmed and I was accorded a red-carpet welcome by the general manager Anil Chadha, with all the employees standing in line and throwing rose petals at me. It was a deeply touching gesture.

After lunch we left for Lahli. It took us approximately two and a half hours to drive to the guest house, but all along the route people were waving banners and posters and all sorts of things, making it a very memorable journey. When we finally reached the guest house, I was surprised to see the butler who had been with me in Delhi already stationed there to take care of us! He informed us that four of them had travelled from Delhi at Anirudh's request and would be looking after us all the way through the match.

At Lahli I felt like trying some local food and asked the manager to recommend some authentic local cuisine. The manager did not say anything in response and left the room, but then he apologized to Zaheer and informed him that Anirudh had left strict instructions about what should be served to us. He had made it clear that every day breakfast, dinner and snacks would come from the ITC Maurya in Delhi and that nothing else should be served, to avoid any risks. I must say it really was a maharaja-style outing. The Haryana Cricket Association had gone out of their way to spoil us.

The stadium was forty minutes away from the guest house but the roads were nearly empty and it was never a problem reaching the ground in the morning. It was a beautiful arena and the conditions were tailor-made for fast bowling. The outfield was a little soft to start with because of the dampness and it would be a good test of my fitness ahead of the West Indies series. Soft outfields can put pressure on calves and hamstrings and if I had no trouble on this outfield, I would be fine at Eden Gardens or the Wankhede, the venues for my 199th and 200th Test matches.

Mumbai's first Ranji match of the season, which was also my last, turned out to be fascinating. A large crowd had come along and the build-up to the four-day game was unprecedented. Media from India and the rest of the cricket-playing world had descended on the small town of Lahli and while the police tried their best to keep them at a distance, I knew that my every move was followed and every practice session filmed.